a source of such great concern for the Western leaders during the interwar years, and the Soviet atomic threat, a source of post-World War II worries, were now gone. And while the memory of World War II was thus fading away, and so was (an important part of) the rationale it provided for the existence of the European Union, the liberal narrative took a twist, being further deepened by the emergence of post-modern thought that pushed the idea of an autonomous individual to the very limits. Critical race, gender and other related theories have become the flagship ideas of the Western left, rather than the condition of the working classes, now almost extinct in a de-industrialised West.

On the other hand, out there in the East, there were peoples, so far largely unknown, that should return to Europe, should adopt the entire canon of the West, and should begin to copy the West. Their historical experience was of limited interest, at times too graphic and brutal for elevated circles or too complex for an ordinary Western voter to understand. And these Easterns then suddenly departed from Europe's way (together with Prime Minister Tony Blair) on a trip with those conservative Americans, as if too naive to understand that it was all about oil and America's lack of sophistication in international affairs. This was the impression at least in the upper circles of Europe's core nations.

In fact, this more sophisticated Europe was right. The invasion of Iraq was an ill-conceived and poorly justified enterprise, as America would acknowledge later. True, a brutal dictator was gone, but the country and the region was thrown out of balance, into years of conflict, civil strife and misery, with only Iran seeming to profit from it.

However, by the outbreak of the 2008 economic crisis, the Iraq episode was almost forgotten. Central Europe was then hit hard by the crisis, with the exception of Poland, which maintained growth due to the size of its domestic market, reliance on local currency and fairly healthy banks. (This Polish exception should not be forgotten, as it provides part of the rationale for later developments.) The Baltic states, Bulgaria, Romania and Hungary had the hardest times. They were more dependent on foreign investments and were heavily exposed to Scandinavian and Austrian banks. (In the Baltics, banks were also exposed to extensive Russian attempts at money laundering.) Eventually, the banking sector was rescued by international financial institutions, and once growth resumed in Germany, the region's